

PRINTABLE CARD DECK • AGES 0–5

# 52 Play & Talk Cards

One play and one talk tip on every card, for babies, toddlers and preschoolers.



## Copy Cat Faces

**NEEDS** Just you  
From birth Prep 0 min  
Hold baby face to face, and see you well. Open wide and out your tongue. Watch

**TALK TIP • REPEAT**  
Copy baby's sounds and becomes "ba-ba!" Then another.

With a grown-up. Start with an item bigger than a toilet-paper roll.

★ 2–3 yrs

## Color Sort

**NEEDS** Big blocks in 3 colors  
From 26 mo Prep 2 min  
Put one of each color in a bag. Let child sort the rest. Mix and sort again.

**TALK TIP • REPEAT**  
"Red" becomes "red"

With a grown-up. Start with an item bigger than a toilet-paper roll.

● 3–5 yrs

## Box Rocket

**NEEDS** A big box, crayons  
From 36 mo Prep 5 min Low mess ~15 min  
Draw buttons and windows on the box. Climb in, count down from ten, and blast off to the moon.

**TALK TIP • FOLLOW THEIR LEAD**  
Ask "Where are we flying? What's out the window?"

With a grown-up. Pull out staples and tape first. A grown-up stays nearby.

▲ 0–1 year

13 PLAYS

■ 1–2 years

13 PLAYS

★ 2–3 years

13 PLAYS

● 3–5 years

13 PLAYS

Prep: about 20 min to print and cut, once. Most plays: 0–2 min to set up.

## Inside this download

- ✓ 54 poker-size cards: 52 plays + how-to + blank
- ✓ Every play: start age, prep, mess, 2-min version
- ✓ Grown-up guide with 8 simple talk moves
- ✓ No-cut play pages: start today, cut later
- ✓ Make-your-own cards you can type into
- ✓ A 52-week play checklist for the fridge

# Start here

Five minutes of play and a little back-and-forth talk. That's the whole idea. No screens, no scripts, nothing to get right.

## How to use the cards

- 1 Find your child's color.**  
Each age has a color and a shape (see the key).  
Ages are a guide, not a rule.
- 2 Pick one card.**  
Or let your child pick. Keep a few by the door, the tub or the toy basket.
- 3 Gather what you need.**  
Almost every play uses things you already have at home.
- 4 Play, then try the talk tip.**  
Say it once, then wait. Their look, sound or point is a turn.
- 5 Stay close and stop while it's fun.**  
Five happy minutes beats twenty tired ones. Play it again tomorrow.

## Age key

 **0–1 year**

**CARDS 01–13**

Faces, voices, peekaboo, and “what happens if I...?”

 **1–2 years**

**CARDS 14–26**

Filling, dumping, climbing and first pretend play

 **2–3 years**

**CARDS 27–39**

Pretend play, sorting, place words and big-paper art

 **3–5 years**

**CARDS 40–52**

Stories, simple games with rules and taking turns

Every child grows at their own pace. Play any card that fits your child today, younger or older. If you have questions about your child's development, your child's doctor is a good place to start.

## The 8 talk moves on the cards



### Pause and wait

Count to five in your head before you help. A look, a sound or a point is a turn.



### Say what you see

Name what your child is looking at or doing, in short, clear words.



### Repeat and add one

Say their word back and add one more: “ball” becomes “big ball.”



### Offer a choice

Hold up two options and wait. Pointing is a real answer.



### Follow their lead

Play what they choose, and talk about what they care about.



### Sing and gesture

Add a tune, a clap or a hand sign. Two ways to join in.



### Take turns

You go, they go. Back-and-forth is the whole point.



### Wonder aloud

Say “I wonder...” instead of quizzing. Then wait and see.

**Why play and talk?** Little ones learn to talk by talking with you: a look, a sound, your answer, their turn. Everyday play gives you lots of those back-and-forth moments, with nothing to buy and nothing to teach.

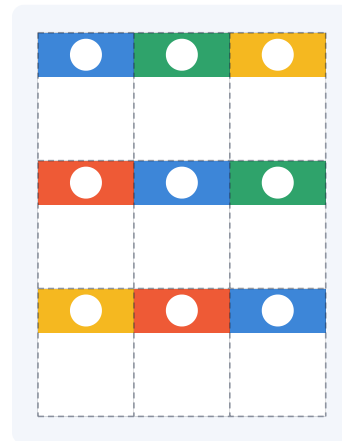
**Three talk lines to try today:** “Your turn!” · “Tell me more.” · “What happens next?” **Talk, sing and read in the language you know best.** A sign, a point or a tap on a talking device counts as a turn.

**Most children love 2–3 of these** and want them again and again. That's perfect: repeat the favorites and skip the rest. Tired day? Every play has a 2-minute version on the no-cut pages.

## BEFORE YOU PRINT

# Print, cut and keep

- ✓ **Print at “Actual size” (100%).** Cards are standard poker size, 2.5 × 3.5 in (63.5 × 88.9 mm).
- ✓ **Use cardstock if you can.** Heavy paper or cardstock (65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm) feels like a real deck.
- ✓ **Edges cut off?** Choose “Fit” instead. The cards print a little smaller and still work.
- ✓ **Backs are optional.** Print the backs page on the reverse of a card sheet, flipping on the long edge. Test one sheet first.
- ✓ **Cut on the lines.** A paper trimmer is fastest. Grown-up keeps the pieces and does the cutting. No time? Use the no-cut pages today.
- ✓ **Make them last.** Laminate for sticky fingers. Keep them in a recipe box, a zip bag or on a ring.



9 cards per page · 6 pages · 54 cards  
Prep: about 20 minutes to print and cut

## ✓ Safety basics built into every card

- A grown-up plays along and stays within reach, every time.
- Under 3: every object is bigger than a toilet-paper tube opening (about 1.25 in / 3.2 cm).
- Water play: a grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.
- No balloons, no long cords or strings, and no choking-risk foods on any card.
- Check toys and boxes for loose parts, staples and tape before play.
- Grown-up keeps the pieces: the paper cards are for grown-up hands, not for mouths.

## FOUNDER'S NOTE · TO BE WRITTEN BY THE FOUNDER IN HER OWN WORDS BEFORE RELEASE

Placeholder for human-authored text (60–90 words): why these cards exist, how your family uses them, and one favorite play. Replace this box; do not publish with it. See brand/BRAND.md, “Human authorship.”

## Ways to use your deck

### Card of the day

Clip one card to the fridge each morning.

### Grab-and-go

Keep a few in the diaper bag for waiting rooms.

### Share the job

Hand a card to grandparents or the sitter.

### Rainy-day pile

Save the indoor plays for stuck-inside days.

**License: PERSONAL.** You may print and copy this for your own family only. No resale, redistribution, sharing, posting, uploading to shared or public drives or websites, or use to train AI. Full terms: [playbeforepixels.com/license](https://playbeforepixels.com/license)

© 2026 AlphaPlay LLC. Play Before Pixels is a trade name of AlphaPlay LLC. All rights reserved. Version 1.0 · September 2026.

# 0-1 year: cards 01-13



With a grown-up, every time. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card.

## PLAY

## HOW TO PLAY

## TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

**01 Peekaboo Cloth**

From 4 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A dish towel

Hide your face behind the towel, then pop out: "Peekaboo!" Later, let baby pull it off your head.  
**Talk: Pause before "boo." A kick, a grin or a squeal is baby's turn.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Hide your face behind your hands: "Where did I go?... Here I am!"  
**EASIER** Hide only half your face so baby can still see you.  
**HARDER** Hide a big toy under the towel and let baby find it.

**02 Copy Cat Faces**

From birth • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~3 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS Just you

Hold baby face to face, close enough to see you well. Open wide, smile big, stick out your tongue. Watch baby try it too.  
**Talk: Copy baby's sounds back: "ba" becomes "ba-ba!" Then wait for another.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** At a diaper change, copy one sound baby makes, then wait.  
**EASIER** Just smile and wait for a smile back.  
**HARDER** Add a sound to each face: "ooh," "ahh," "mmm."

**03 Kitchen Drum**

From 6 mo • Prep 1 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A pot and a wooden spoon

Turn the pot upside down on the floor. Tap it, then hand baby the spoon. Take turns: soft, then loud.  
**Talk: Name the sounds as they happen: "Bang! Bang! Soft... LOUD!"**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Tap a beat on your knees. Wait for baby to pat too.  
**EASIER** Hold baby's hand and tap the pot together.  
**HARDER** Add a plastic bowl: which one sounds louder?

**04 Where's Duck?**

From 6 mo • Prep 1 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A big toy and a towel

Hide the toy under the towel with a little bit showing. Ask "Where's duck?" and let baby find it. Cheer!  
**Talk: Ask, then count to five in your head before you help.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Hide the toy behind your back, then bring it out: "There it is!"  
**EASIER** Leave most of the toy showing.  
**HARDER** Hide it all the way, under one of two towels.

**05 Bubble Watch**

From 6 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min  
NEEDS Bubbles

Blow a few bubbles slowly above baby. Let baby watch, reach and pop. Blow again when baby looks at you.  
**Talk: Use the same short words each time: "Up, up... pop!"**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Blow three bubbles and say "pop, pop, pop" as they burst.  
**EASIER** Blow one bubble at a time, slowly.  
**HARDER** Catch a bubble on the wand for baby to poke.

**06 Rock and Stop**

From birth • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A song you know

Hold baby and sway while you sing. Stop in the middle and wait. Start again when baby wiggles or looks at you.  
**Talk: The pause is the game. Baby's wiggle means "more!"**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Sway through one line of any song, then pause.  
**EASIER** Pause for just a second at first.  
**HARDER** Stop at a different spot each time and wait longer.

**07 Roll It Back**

From 7 mo • Prep 1 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A big soft ball

For babies who can sit: sit facing each other, legs apart. Roll the ball to baby, then help roll it back.  
**Talk: Say "Ready... roll!" and wait for baby to look at you first.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Roll the ball once from your lap into baby's hands.  
**EASIER** Sit close together, just a short roll apart.  
**HARDER** Scoot back a little farther after each roll.

**08 First Book Chat**

From 3 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A board book

Sit baby on your lap. Point to one picture and name it. Let baby pat the pictures and help turn the pages.  
**Talk: Talk about whatever baby looks at, even the same page again.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Name one picture on one page, then close the book.  
**EASIER** Stay on one page and let baby pat it.  
**HARDER** Ask "Where's the dog?" and wait for a look or a point.

**09 In and Out**

From 8 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A basket and 4-5 big toys

Drop toys into the basket one by one: "In!" Tip them out: "Out!" Let baby dump and fill.  
**Talk: One word for each move: "in," "out," "all gone!"**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Drop one toy in: "In!" Tip it out: "Out!"  
**EASIER** Use one toy and a wide basket.  
**HARDER** Use a box with a smaller opening (big toys only).

**10 Leaf Hello**

From 3 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A tree or a big plant

Carry baby close to a tree or a window plant. Touch a leaf together, look up at the sky, feel the breeze.  
**Talk: Name it, then add one word: "Leaf. Green leaf. Soft leaf."**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Stand at a window and name one thing outside.  
**EASIER** Just look up and feel the breeze together.  
**HARDER** Touch two leaves: big and small, smooth and bumpy.

**11 Tickle Countdown**

From 4 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~3 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS Just you

Wiggle your fingers in the air: "One... two... three..." then a gentle tickle. Do it again, a little slower.  
**Talk: Stop at "two..." A squeal or a kick asks for "three!"**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** One slow countdown, one gentle tickle, then a cuddle.  
**EASIER** Skip the countdown: wiggle your fingers, then tickle.  
**HARDER** Pause longer at "two..." and wait for baby to ask.

**12 Stack and Crash**

From 6 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS Plastic cups or big blocks

Stack three cups into a tower. Let baby knock it over. Cheer, and build it again together.  
**Talk: Say "up, up, up... crash!" and throw your arms wide on "crash."**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Stack two cups and let baby knock them over.  
**EASIER** Stack just two cups.  
**HARDER** Help baby put a cup on top before the crash.

**13 Sock Off!**

From 6 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~3 min • **nothing to buy**  
NEEDS A clean grown-up sock

Slip a big, loose sock halfway onto baby's foot. Let baby pull it off: "Sock off!" Try the other foot.  
**Talk: Say it as it happens: "Foot! Sock on... sock off!"**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** At a diaper change, say each step: "Sock off. Sock on."  
**EASIER** Pull the sock most of the way off first.  
**HARDER** Slip it over baby's hand instead: "Where did your hand go?"

# 1-2 years: cards 14-26

✓ With a grown-up, every time. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card.

## PLAY

## HOW TO PLAY

## TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

## 14 Box Car

From 12 mo • Prep 3 min • No mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A big cardboard box

Your toddler sits in the box. Push it slowly around the room. Stop at "stations" to wave hello.

**Talk:** Say "Ready, set..." and wait for "go!" Any sound counts.

2-MINUTE VERSION Sit in the box together and pretend to drive: "Beep beep!"

EASIER Push slowly in a straight line.

HARDER Let them push a teddy in the box over to you.

## 15 Stir the Soup

From 12 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A pot, a big spoon, big blocks

Drop blocks into the pot and stir. Blow on the "hot" soup. Serve a spoonful to a teddy.

**Talk:** Ask "Hot soup or cold soup?" Hold up two hands and wait.

2-MINUTE VERSION Hand over a spoon and an empty pot. Taste it: "Mmm!"

EASIER Just drop the blocks in and take them out.

HARDER Ask for two "ingredients": a red block and a blue one.

## 16 Animal Voices

From 12 mo • Prep 1 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Big toy animals or a picture book

Hold up an animal and make its sound. Pass it to your child. Swap animals and go again.

**Talk:** Say "The cow says..." and leave a gap for "moo."

2-MINUTE VERSION Make one animal sound and wait for them to copy.

EASIER Use one animal they know well.

HARDER Make the sound and let them find the animal.

## 17 Pour and Splash

From 12 mo • Prep 3 min • Messy • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A tub of water, 2 plastic cups

Set the tub on a towel. Pour water from cup to cup. Let your child pour, splash and fill.

**Talk:** Talk as it happens: "Full... empty! Pour, pour."

2-MINUTE VERSION At bath time, with you right there, pour water from cup to cup: "Pour!"

EASIER Fill the cups halfway so they stay light.

HARDER Add a colander or a funnel to pour through.

## 18 Block Tower

From 14 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min

NEEDS Big blocks

Build a tower together, one block each. Count as you go. Let them knock it down and start again.

**Talk:** They say "block," you say "big block!"

2-MINUTE VERSION Stack two blocks and knock them down together.

EASIER Use empty boxes: big and light.

HARDER Count each block out loud as it goes on.

## 19 Hat Parade

From 12 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS 3-4 hats from around the house

Try on hats in front of a mirror. Make a silly face in each one. March around the room.

**Talk:** Ask "Sun hat or winter hat?" Let them choose yours too.

2-MINUTE VERSION Put one hat on your head: "Hat!" Let them pull it off.

EASIER Use one hat and the mirror.

HARDER Let them choose a hat for each teddy.

## 20 Pillow Mountain

From 12 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Couch cushions

Pile the cushions on the floor to make a mountain. Help your child climb up, then slide down.

**Talk:** Say it as they move: "Up, up, up! Down!"

2-MINUTE VERSION Lie on the floor and let them climb over your legs.

EASIER Two cushions only, low and flat.

HARDER Add a crawl-under "cave" between two cushions.

## 21 Sock Toss

From 15 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Rolled-up pairs of socks, a basket

Toss the sock balls into the basket. Find a big one and a little one. Balance one on your head!

**Talk:** "Sock" becomes "big sock!" or "red sock!"

2-MINUTE VERSION Toss three sock balls into the basket together.

EASIER Put the basket right next to them.

HARDER Step back one big step after each throw.

## 22 Teddy's Bedtime

From 15 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A stuffed toy, a small towel

Tuck teddy in with the towel. Read teddy a book, sing teddy a song, whisper "night-night."

**Talk:** If they feed teddy instead, talk about the snack.

2-MINUTE VERSION Tuck teddy in and whisper "night-night" together.

EASIER Just cover teddy with the towel.

HARDER Let them choose teddy's book and teddy's song.

## 23 Chair Tunnel

From 12 mo • Prep 3 min • No mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Two chairs and a blanket

Drape the blanket over two chairs to make a tunnel. Crawl through together, then take turns.

**Talk:** Say the word as they move: "In... through... out!"

2-MINUTE VERSION Crawl under the table together: "In... out!"

EASIER Make it short: one chair and the blanket.

HARDER Add a pillow to crawl over at the end.

## 24 Clap and Stomp

From 12 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~3 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Just you

Clap twice, stomp twice, pat your knees. Let your child copy you, then you copy their moves.

**Talk:** Copy whatever they do. They're the leader now.

2-MINUTE VERSION Clap twice, wait, and see if they clap back.

EASIER Do one move at a time.

HARDER Do two moves in a row: clap, then stomp.

## 25 Pull-Out Box

From 12 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS An empty tissue box, 6 washcloths

Stuff the washcloths into the box. Your child pulls them out one by one. Stuff them back in and go again.

**Talk:** Hold one up: "More?" Wait for a look, a point or a sound.

2-MINUTE VERSION Tuck a washcloth in your sleeve and let them pull it out.

EASIER Leave the cloths sticking out a little.

HARDER Ask them to stuff the cloths back in and hand you the box.

## 26 Kick and Chase

From 15 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A big soft ball

Roll or kick the ball across the room. Race to it together. Catch it and sit on it!

**Talk:** Ask "Kick it or roll it?" Show both, then wait.

2-MINUTE VERSION Roll the ball to them from where you sit.

EASIER Roll it gently, a short way.

HARDER Kick it toward a "goal" between two cushions.

# ★ 2–3 years: cards 27–39



With a grown-up, every time. Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube. Card-specific safety notes are on each card.

## PLAY

## HOW TO PLAY

## TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

**27 Blanket Fort**

From 24 mo • Prep 5 min • Low mess • ~15 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A blanket, chairs, pillows

Build a fort together. Bring in a book and a teddy. Read inside, then peek out the door.

**Talk: Use place words: “in,” “under,” “on top,” “behind.”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Drape a blanket over the table and read one book under it.

**EASIER** One blanket over one chair.

**HARDER** Add a door flap and a secret knock.

**28 Tea Party**

From 24 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Plastic cups and plates, stuffed toys

Set a pretend table for the toys. Pour pretend tea, pass pretend cake, and clink cups: “Cheers!”

**Talk: Ask as Bear: “More tea? Milk or honey?” Wait for the answer.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Pour pretend tea for one toy and say “Cheers!”

**EASIER** One cup and one toy.

**HARDER** Let them take each toy’s order.

**29 Color Sort**

From 26 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess • ~10 min

NEEDS Big blocks in 3 colors, 3 bowls

Put one of each color in a bowl. Your child sorts the rest. Mix them all up and sort again.

**Talk: “Red” becomes “red block goes here!”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Sort a few grown-up socks: dark ones, light ones.

**EASIER** Start with just two colors.

**HARDER** Add a fourth color, or sort by size too.

**30 Car Ramp**

From 24 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~10 min

NEEDS A board or big book, big toy cars

Prop the board on the sofa to make a ramp. Race the cars down. Which one goes the farthest?

**Talk: Say what happens: “Fast! Slow! Crash!”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Tilt a big book and let one car roll down.

**EASIER** Keep the ramp low.

**HARDER** Guess which car will go farther, then test it.

**31 Big Paper Art**

From 24 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess • ~10 min

NEEDS Big paper, jumbo egg-shaped crayons, tape

Tape the paper to the floor. Draw lines, dots and circles side by side. Swap crayons now and then.

**Talk: Describe, don’t quiz: “Round and round. A big circle!”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Draw one big circle together, then add two eyes.

**EASIER** One color, big lines.

**HARDER** Take turns: you draw a line, they add to it.

**32 Freeze Dance**

From 24 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A song to sing or play

Dance to a song. When the music stops, freeze! Take turns being the one who stops the music.

**Talk: Let your child shout “stop!” and “go!” for you.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Sing one line, stop, and freeze together.

**EASIER** Freeze for just a second.

**HARDER** Freeze in a shape: tall, tiny or wide.

**33 Sock Puppet Chat**

From 24 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A clean grown-up sock, a marker (yours)

Draw eyes on the sock and slip it on your hand. The puppet says hello, asks a question, then waits.

**Talk: Puppets are patient. Give extra time to answer.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Put your hand in a sock and say hello in a squeaky voice.

**EASIER** The puppet just waves and says hello.

**HARDER** Make two puppets and let them talk to each other.

**34 Nature Basket**

From 24 mo • Prep 0 min • Low mess • ~15 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A basket, a walk outside

Collect big leaves, sticks and pinecones. At home, sort them: bumpy, smooth, big, small.

**Talk: Name how they feel: “Bumpy pinecone. Smooth stick.”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** On your next walk, pick up one big leaf and name its color.

**EASIER** Collect only leaves.

**HARDER** Sort by two things: big and bumpy, small and smooth.

**35 Pretend Shop**

From 26 mo • Prep 3 min • Low mess • ~15 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Empty food boxes, a bag

Set up a shop on the sofa. Your child fills the bag and pays you with a high five. Then swap jobs.

**Talk: Ask “Cereal or crackers today?” and wait.**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Hold out your hand: “One apple, please!” Pay with a high five.

**EASIER** Just fill the bag and carry it.

**HARDER** Ask for amounts: “Two boxes, please.”

**36 Toy Bath**

From 24 mo • Prep 3 min • Messy • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A tub of water, a washable toy, a cloth

Give the toy a bath: wash its hands, feet and tummy. Dry it off and tuck it in.

**Talk: Name body parts: “Wash the toes. Now the knees!”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Wipe a toy’s feet with a damp cloth: “Scrub, scrub!”

**EASIER** Use a damp cloth instead of a tub.

**HARDER** Ask “What should we wash next?” and let them choose.

**37 Animal Moves**

From 24 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Space to move

Hop like a frog, stomp like an elephant, tiptoe like a cat. Take turns picking the animal.

**Talk: Add the sound and the move: “Hop, hop, ribbit!”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Pick one animal and hop like a frog three times.

**EASIER** Copy your moves, slowly.

**HARDER** Guess the animal from the move alone.

**38 Shape Hunt**

From 30 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Just you

Walk around the house looking for circles: a plate, a clock, a wheel. Then hunt for squares.

**Talk: Point and name: “Round, like the clock!”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Find one circle in the room you’re sitting in.

**EASIER** Hunt for circles only.

**HARDER** Hunt for triangles too.

**39 Little Helper**

From 24 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A cloth damp with plain water

Wipe the table together after a meal. Then let your child wipe a chair, then a toy.

**Talk: Talk as you work: “Wipe, wipe. All clean!”**

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Hand over the cloth for one wipe of the table: “All clean!”

**EASIER** Give them one spot to wipe.

**HARDER** Wipe, then set out the spoons for dinner.

# 3–5 years: cards 40–52



With a grown-up, every time. A grown-up plays along and stays nearby. Card-specific safety notes are on each card.

## PLAY

## HOW TO PLAY

## TIRED DAY • EASIER • HARDER

**40 Story Box**

From 36 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A box, 3 toys from around the house

Pull out 3 toys. Make up a story that uses all three. Take turns adding one sentence each.

**Talk:** Let the story go anywhere. Ask, “And then what?”

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Tell a one-minute story about any toy in the room.

**EASIER** Use one toy and ask “What happened next?”

**HARDER** Add a problem: “Uh-oh! Then what?”

**41 Obstacle Course**

From 36 mo • Prep 5 min • Low mess • ~15 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Pillows, a chair, a blanket

Build a course: crawl under the chair, hop over the pillows, roll across the blanket.

**Talk:** Give two-step directions: “Crawl under, then jump!” Then swap.

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Two steps only: crawl under the table, then hop.

**EASIER** Just one or two steps.

**HARDER** Give three-step directions, then swap who gives them.

**42 I Spy Colors**

From 36 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Just you

“I spy something green.” Your child guesses. Then they pick something and give you the clue.

**Talk:** If they get stuck, add a hint: “It’s round...”

**2-MINUTE VERSION** One round of “I spy something blue.”

**EASIER** Point to the area while you give the clue.

**HARDER** Spy by sound: “something that starts with b.”

**43 Restaurant**

From 36 mo • Prep 5 min • Low mess • ~15 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Paper, crayons, plates

Draw a menu together. Your child takes your order, “cooks” it and brings it to the table. Swap roles.

**Talk:** Ask “Soup or pizza? Anything else?”

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Ask “What’s on the menu tonight?” and order from your chair.

**EASIER** Skip the menu; just take your order.

**HARDER** Let them “write” the order and bring the bill.

**44 Box Rocket**

From 36 mo • Prep 5 min • Low mess • ~15 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A big box, crayons

Draw buttons and windows on the box. Climb in, count down from ten, and blast off to the moon.

**Talk:** Ask “Where are we flying? What’s out the window?”

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Sit on the floor, count down from five and blast off with your arms.

**EASIER** Count down from five.

**HARDER** Plan the trip: what do we pack for the moon?

**45 Kitchen List**

From 42 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Paper, a crayon

Draw a list together: an apple, a cup, a spoon. Hunt for each one in the kitchen and check it off.

**Talk:** “Found the spoon! What’s next on our list?”

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Name three things to find in the room you’re in.

**EASIER** Draw just two things.

**HARDER** Add one tricky item: “something round.”

**46 Do What I Do**

From 36 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Just you

Touch your nose, hop on one foot, spin around once. Your child copies. Then they’re the leader.

**Talk:** Being the leader means practicing clear directions.

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Touch your nose and wait for them to copy. Then swap.

**EASIER** One move at a time.

**HARDER** Two moves in a row: “Clap, then spin.”

**47 Shadow Animals**

From 36 mo • Prep 2 min • No mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A flashlight, a wall

Dim the lights. Shine the flashlight on a wall and make hand shadows: a bird, a dog, a crocodile.

**Talk:** Ask “What animal is this?” Let them guess, then try a new one.

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Make one hand shadow with the flashlight and let them name it.

**EASIER** Wiggle your hand and let them chase the shadow.

**HARDER** Make up a short shadow story together.

**48 Book Bridge**

From 36 mo • Prep 3 min • Low mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS Books or blocks, toy cars

Build a bridge between two stacks. Drive cars over it. Make it longer. Will it hold?

**Talk:** Say “I wonder if it will hold?” Then wait and see.

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Lay one book across two stacks and drive one car over.

**EASIER** Keep the stacks low.

**HARDER** Make it longer. How many books before it falls?

**49 Sock Match**

From 36 mo • Prep 1 min • Low mess • ~10 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A pile of clean socks

Dump the socks out. Race to find matching pairs. Roll each pair into a ball.

**Talk:** Hold up two: “Same or different?”

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Find one matching pair in the laundry basket.

**EASIER** Start with 3 pairs that look very different.

**HARDER** Race: who finds the most pairs?

**50 Water Painting**

From 36 mo • Prep 2 min • Low mess • ~15 min

NEEDS A cup of water, a paintbrush

Outside, “paint” a fence, a step or the sidewalk with water. Watch the picture dry and disappear.

**Talk:** “Where did it go? I wonder if the sun dried it.”

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Dip your fingers in a cup and paint one line on a step.

**EASIER** Paint with fingers instead of a brush.

**HARDER** Paint a shape and guess each other’s.

**51 Feelings Faces**

From 36 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~5 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A wall mirror or an unbreakable one

Make faces in the mirror together: happy, sad, surprised, grumpy. Guess each other’s face.

**Talk:** “Your eyebrows went up. Surprised!” Ask when they felt that way.

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Make one face and let them guess it.

**EASIER** Try only happy and sad.

**HARDER** Act out what made you feel that way.

**52 Sound Walk**

From 36 mo • Prep 0 min • No mess • ~15 min • [nothing to buy](#)

NEEDS A walk outside

Stand still and listen. Count sounds on your fingers: a bird, a car, the wind. Walk on and listen again.

**Talk:** Whisper “What do you hear?” Take turns naming sounds.

**2-MINUTE VERSION** Open a window and count three sounds together.

**EASIER** Count just two sounds.

**HARDER** Stand still, close your eyes and guess each sound.

START HERE

# How to play

- 1 Find your child's color.
- 2 Pick a card, or let your child pick.
- 3 Play while it's fun. Stop before it isn't.
- 4 Try the talk tip. Then wait.

▲ 0–1 year    ■ 1–2 years  
★ 2–3 years    ● 3–5 years



- ✓ Every card: a grown-up plays along and stays within reach.

Version 1.0 · September 2026

▲ 0–1 yr



01

## Peekaboo Cloth

NEEDS A dish towel

👤 From 4 mo    ⏱ Prep 0 min    💧 No mess    ⌚ ~5 min

Hide your face behind the towel, then pop out: “Peekaboo!” Later, let baby pull it off your head.

**TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT**  
Pause before “boo.” A kick, a grin or a squeal is baby's turn.

- ✓ **With a grown-up.** Put the towel away after play; never leave it in the crib.

▲ 0–1 yr



02

## Copy Cat Faces

NEEDS Just you

👤 From birth    ⏱ Prep 0 min    💧 No mess    ⌚ ~3 min

Hold baby face to face, close enough to see you well. Open wide, smile big, stick out your tongue. Watch baby try it too.

**TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE**  
Copy baby's sounds back: “ba” becomes “ba-ba!” Then wait for another.

- ✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



03

## Kitchen Drum

NEEDS A pot and a wooden spoon

👤 From 6 mo    ⏱ Prep 1 min    💧 No mess    ⌚ ~5 min

Turn the pot upside down on the floor. Tap it, then hand baby the spoon. Take turns: soft, then loud.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**  
Name the sounds as they happen: “Bang! Bang! Soft... LOUD!”

- ✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



04

## Where's Duck?

NEEDS A big toy and a towel

👤 From 6 mo    ⏱ Prep 1 min    💧 No mess    ⌚ ~5 min

Hide the toy under the towel with a little bit showing. Ask “Where's duck?” and let baby find it. Cheer!

**TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT**  
Ask, then count to five in your head before you help.

- ✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



05

## Bubble Watch

NEEDS Bubbles

👤 From 6 mo    ⏱ Prep 1 min    💧 Low mess    ⌚ ~5 min

Blow a few bubbles slowly above baby. Let baby watch, reach and pop. Blow again when baby looks at you.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**  
Use the same short words each time: “Up, up... pop!”

- ✓ **With a grown-up.** You hold the bottle and blow away from baby's face. Wipe little hands.

▲ 0–1 yr



06

## Rock and Stop

NEEDS A song you know

👤 From birth    ⏱ Prep 0 min    💧 No mess    ⌚ ~5 min

Hold baby and sway while you sing. Stop in the middle and wait. Start again when baby wiggles or looks at you.

**TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE**  
The pause is the game. Baby's wiggle means “more!”

- ✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



07

## Roll It Back

NEEDS A big soft ball

👤 From 7 mo    ⏱ Prep 1 min    💧 No mess    ⌚ ~5 min

For babies who can sit: sit facing each other, legs apart. Roll the ball to baby, then help roll it back.

**TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT**  
Say “Ready... roll!” and wait for baby to look at you first.

- ✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



08

## First Book Chat

NEEDS A board book

👤 From 3 mo    ⏱ Prep 0 min    💧 No mess    ⌚ ~5 min

Sit baby on your lap. Point to one picture and name it. Let baby pat the pictures and help turn the pages.

**TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD**  
Talk about whatever baby looks at, even the same page again.

- ✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



09

## In and Out

**NEEDS** A basket and 4–5 big toys

👤 From 8 mo 🔄 Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Drop toys into the basket one by one: “In!” Tip them out: “Out!” Let baby dump and fill.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**

One word for each move: “in,” “out,” “all gone!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



10

## Leaf Hello

**NEEDS** A tree or a big plant

👤 From 3 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Carry baby close to a tree or a window plant. Touch a leaf together, look up at the sky, feel the breeze.

**TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE**

Name it, then add one word: “Leaf. Green leaf. Soft leaf.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Leaves and petals stay out of mouths.

▲ 0–1 yr



11

## Tickle Countdown

**NEEDS** Just you

👤 From 4 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~3 min

Wiggle your fingers in the air: “One... two... three...” then a gentle tickle. Do it again, a little slower.

**TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT**

Stop at “two...” A squeal or a kick asks for “three!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



12

## Stack and Crash

**NEEDS** Plastic cups or big blocks

👤 From 6 mo 🔄 Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Stack three cups into a tower. Let baby knock it over. Cheer, and build it again together.

**TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE**

Say “up, up, up... crash!” and throw your arms wide on “crash.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

▲ 0–1 yr



13

## Sock Off!

**NEEDS** A clean grown-up sock

👤 From 6 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~3 min

Slip a big, loose sock halfway onto baby's foot. Let baby pull it off: “Sock off!” Try the other foot.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**

Say it as it happens: “Foot! Sock on... sock off!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Put the sock away after play; socks stay out of mouths.

■ 1–2 yrs



14

## Box Car

**NEEDS** A big cardboard box

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 3 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Your toddler sits in the box. Push it slowly around the room. Stop at “stations” to wave hello.

**TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT**

Say “Ready, set...” and wait for “go!” Any sound counts.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Push slowly on the floor. Pull out staples and tape first.

■ 1–2 yrs



15

## Stir the Soup

**NEEDS** A pot, a big spoon, big blocks

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

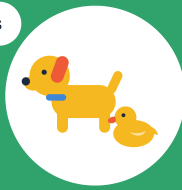
Drop blocks into the pot and stir. Blow on the “hot” soup. Serve a spoonful to a teddy.

**TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE**

Ask “Hot soup or cold soup?” Hold up two hands and wait.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

■ 1–2 yrs



16

## Animal Voices

**NEEDS** Big toy animals or a picture book

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 1 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Hold up an animal and make its sound. Pass it to your child. Swap animals and go again.

**TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT**

Say “The cow says...” and leave a gap for “moo.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

■ 1–2 yrs



17

## Pour and Splash

**NEEDS** A tub of water, 2 plastic cups

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 3 min 💧 Messy ⌚ ~10 min

Set the tub on a towel. Pour water from cup to cup. Let your child pour, splash and fill.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**

Talk as it happens: “Full... empty! Pour, pour.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Water play: a grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.

1–2 yrs



18

## Block Tower

NEEDS Big blocks

👤 From 14 mo 🔄 Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Build a tower together, one block each. Count as you go. Let them knock it down and start again.

**TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE**  
They say “block,” you say “big block!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs



19

## Hat Parade

NEEDS 3–4 hats from around the house

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Try on hats in front of a mirror. Make a silly face in each one. March around the room.

**TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE**  
Ask “Sun hat or winter hat?” Let them choose yours too.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Only hats with no ties, cords or pom-poms. Stay within reach.

1–2 yrs



20

## Pillow Mountain

NEEDS Couch cushions

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 2 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Pile the cushions on the floor to make a mountain. Help your child climb up, then slide down.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**  
Say it as they move: “Up, up, up! Down!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** On the floor, away from furniture corners. Stay within reach.

1–2 yrs



21

## Sock Toss

NEEDS Rolled-up pairs of socks, a basket

👤 From 15 mo 🔄 Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Toss the sock balls into the basket. Find a big one and a little one. Balance one on your head!

**TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE**  
“Sock” becomes “big sock!” or “red sock!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs



22

## Teddy's Bedtime

NEEDS A stuffed toy, a small towel

👤 From 15 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Tuck teddy in with the towel. Read teddy a book, sing teddy a song, whisper “night-night.”

**TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD**  
If they feed teddy instead, talk about the snack.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs



23

## Chair Tunnel

NEEDS Two chairs and a blanket

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 3 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Drape the blanket over two chairs to make a tunnel. Crawl through together, then take turns.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**  
Say the word as they move: “In... through... out!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Use sturdy chairs that won't tip. Stay within reach.

1–2 yrs



24

## Clap and Stomp

NEEDS Just you

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~3 min

Clap twice, stomp twice, pat your knees. Let your child copy you, then you copy their moves.

**TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD**  
Copy whatever they do. They're the leader now.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

1–2 yrs



25

## Pull-Out Box

NEEDS An empty tissue box, 6 washcloths

👤 From 12 mo 🔄 Prep 2 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Stuff the washcloths into the box. Your child pulls them out one by one. Stuff them back in and go again.

**TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT**  
Hold one up: “More?” Wait for a look, a point or a sound.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Pull out the plastic film from the box opening first. Stay within reach.

1–2 yrs



26

## Kick and Chase

NEEDS A big soft ball

👤 From 15 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Roll or kick the ball across the room. Race to it together. Catch it and sit on it!

**TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE**  
Ask “Kick it or roll it?” Show both, then wait.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



27

## Blanket Fort

**NEEDS** A blanket, chairs, pillows

👤 From 24 mo 🛠️ Prep 5 min 🧼 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Build a fort together. Bring in a book and a teddy. Read inside, then peek out the door.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**

Use place words: “in,” “under,” “on top,” “behind.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Sturdy chairs only; nothing heavy on top. Stay within reach.

★ 2–3 yrs



28

## Tea Party

**NEEDS** Plastic cups and plates, stuffed toys

👤 From 24 mo 🛠️ Prep 2 min 🧼 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Set a pretend table for the toys. Pour pretend tea, pass pretend cake, and clink cups: “Cheers!”

**TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE**

Ask as Bear: “More tea? Milk or honey?” Wait for the answer.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



29

## Color Sort

**NEEDS** Big blocks in 3 colors, 3 bowls

👤 From 26 mo 🛠️ Prep 2 min 🧼 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Put one of each color in a bowl. Your child sorts the rest. Mix them all up and sort again.

**TALK TIP · REPEAT AND ADD ONE**

“Red” becomes “red block goes here!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



30

## Car Ramp

**NEEDS** A board or big book, big toy cars

👤 From 24 mo 🛠️ Prep 2 min 🧼 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Prop the board on the sofa to make a ramp. Race the cars down. Which one goes the farthest?

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**

Say what happens: “Fast! Slow! Crash!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Only cars bigger than a toilet-paper tube, with no loose wheels.

★ 2–3 yrs



31

## Big Paper Art

**NEEDS** Big paper, jumbo egg-shaped crayons, tape

👤 From 24 mo 🛠️ Prep 2 min 🧼 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Tape the paper to the floor. Draw lines, dots and circles side by side. Swap crayons now and then.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**

Describe, don’t quiz: “Round and round. A big circle!”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Crayons too big to fit in a toilet-paper tube. Toss broken bits.

★ 2–3 yrs



32

## Freeze Dance

**NEEDS** A song to sing or play

👤 From 24 mo 🛠️ Prep 0 min 🧼 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

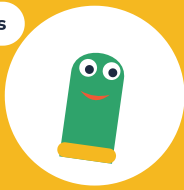
Dance to a song. When the music stops, freeze! Take turns being the one who stops the music.

**TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD**

Let your child shout “stop!” and “go!” for you.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs



33

## Sock Puppet Chat

**NEEDS** A clean grown-up sock, a marker (yours)

👤 From 24 mo 🛠️ Prep 2 min 🧼 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Draw eyes on the sock and slip it on your hand. The puppet says hello, asks a question, then waits.

**TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT**

Puppets are patient. Give extra time to answer.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Draw the face on: no buttons or stick-on eyes. You keep the marker.

★ 2–3 yrs



34

## Nature Basket

**NEEDS** A basket, a walk outside

👤 From 24 mo 🛠️ Prep 0 min 🧼 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Collect big leaves, sticks and pinecones. At home, sort them: bumpy, smooth, big, small.

**TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE**

Name how they feel: “Bumpy pinecone. Smooth stick.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Only things bigger than a toilet-paper tube. No berries or mushrooms. Wash hands after.

★ 2–3 yrs



35

## Pretend Shop

**NEEDS** Empty food boxes, a bag

👤 From 26 mo 🛠️ Prep 3 min 🧼 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Set up a shop on the sofa. Your child fills the bag and pays you with a high five. Then swap jobs.

**TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE**

Ask “Cereal or crackers today?” and wait.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

36



## Toy Bath

**NEEDS** A tub of water, a washable toy, a cloth

👤 From 24 mo 🔄 Prep 3 min 💧 Messy ⌚ ~10 min

Give the toy a bath: wash its hands, feet and tummy. Dry it off and tuck it in.

### TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Name body parts: "Wash the toes. Now the knees!"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Water play: a grown-up within arm's reach the whole time. Tip the water out after.

★ 2–3 yrs

37



## Animal Moves

**NEEDS** Space to move

👤 From 24 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Hop like a frog, stomp like an elephant, tiptoe like a cat. Take turns picking the animal.

### TALK TIP · SING AND GESTURE

Add the sound and the move: "Hop, hop, ribbit!"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

38



## Shape Hunt

**NEEDS** Just you

👤 From 30 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Walk around the house looking for circles: a plate, a clock, a wheel. Then hunt for squares.

### TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Point and name: "Round, like the clock!"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Stay within reach. Every item bigger than a toilet-paper tube.

★ 2–3 yrs

39



## Little Helper

**NEEDS** A cloth damp with plain water

👤 From 24 mo 🔄 Prep 1 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~5 min

Wipe the table together after a meal. Then let your child wipe a chair, then a toy.

### TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

Talk as you work: "Wipe, wipe. All clean!"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Plain water only: no sprays or wipes. Stay within reach.

● 3–5 yrs

40



## Story Box

**NEEDS** A box, 3 toys from around the house

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 2 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Pull out 3 toys. Make up a story that uses all three. Take turns adding one sentence each.

### TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Let the story go anywhere. Ask, "And then what?"

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

41



## Obstacle Course

**NEEDS** Pillows, a chair, a blanket

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Build a course: crawl under the chair, hop over the pillows, roll across the blanket.

### TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Give two-step directions: "Crawl under, then jump!" Then swap.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Clear the space of sharp corners. A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

42



## I Spy Colors

**NEEDS** Just you

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 0 min 💧 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

"I spy something green." Your child guesses. Then they pick something and give you the clue.

### TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

If they get stuck, add a hint: "It's round..."

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

43



## Restaurant

**NEEDS** Paper, crayons, plates

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Draw a menu together. Your child takes your order, "cooks" it and brings it to the table. Swap roles.

### TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Ask "Soup or pizza? Anything else?"

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs

44



## Box Rocket

**NEEDS** A big box, crayons

👤 From 36 mo 🔄 Prep 5 min 💧 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Draw buttons and windows on the box. Climb in, count down from ten, and blast off to the moon.

### TALK TIP · FOLLOW THEIR LEAD

Ask "Where are we flying? What's out the window?"

✓ **With a grown-up.** Pull out staples and tape first. A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



45

## Kitchen List

NEEDS Paper, a crayon

👤 From 42 mo 📏 Prep 2 min 🔥 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Draw a list together: an apple, a cup, a spoon. Hunt for each one in the kitchen and check it off.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

“Found the spoon! What’s next on our list?”

✓ **With a grown-up.** You choose the list. Knives, the stove and cleaners stay off it.

● 3–5 yrs



46

## Do What I Do

NEEDS Just you

👤 From 36 mo 📏 Prep 0 min 🔥 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Touch your nose, hop on one foot, spin around once. Your child copies. Then they’re the leader.

TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Being the leader means practicing clear directions.

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



47

## Shadow Animals

NEEDS A flashlight, a wall

👤 From 36 mo 📏 Prep 2 min 🔥 No mess ⌚ ~10 min

Dim the lights. Shine the flashlight on a wall and make hand shadows: a bird, a dog, a crocodile.

TALK TIP · PAUSE AND WAIT

Ask “What animal is this?” Let them guess, then try a new one.

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up holds the flashlight. Battery covers stay shut.

● 3–5 yrs



48

## Book Bridge

NEEDS Books or blocks, toy cars

👤 From 36 mo 📏 Prep 3 min 🔥 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Build a bridge between two stacks. Drive cars over it. Make it longer. Will it hold?

TALK TIP · WONDER ALOUD

Say “I wonder if it will hold?” Then wait and see.

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



49

## Sock Match

NEEDS A pile of clean socks

👤 From 36 mo 📏 Prep 1 min 🔥 Low mess ⌚ ~10 min

Dump the socks out. Race to find matching pairs. Roll each pair into a ball.

TALK TIP · OFFER A CHOICE

Hold up two: “Same or different?”

✓ **With a grown-up.** A grown-up plays along and stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



50

## Water Painting

NEEDS A cup of water, a paintbrush

👤 From 36 mo 📏 Prep 2 min 🔥 Low mess ⌚ ~15 min

Outside, “paint” a fence, a step or the sidewalk with water. Watch the picture dry and disappear.

TALK TIP · WONDER ALOUD

“Where did it go? I wonder if the sun dried it.”

✓ **With a grown-up.** Water play: a grown-up within arm’s reach, away from the street.

● 3–5 yrs



51

## Feelings Faces

NEEDS A wall mirror or an unbreakable one

👤 From 36 mo 📏 Prep 0 min 🔥 No mess ⌚ ~5 min

Make faces in the mirror together: happy, sad, surprised, grumpy. Guess each other’s face.

TALK TIP · SAY WHAT YOU SEE

“Your eyebrows went up. Surprised!” Ask when they felt that way.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Use a wall mirror or an unbreakable one. A grown-up stays nearby.

● 3–5 yrs



52

## Sound Walk

NEEDS A walk outside

👤 From 36 mo 📏 Prep 0 min 🔥 No mess ⌚ ~15 min

Stand still and listen. Count sounds on your fingers: a bird, a car, the wind. Walk on and listen again.

TALK TIP · TAKE TURNS

Whisper “What do you hear?” Take turns naming sounds.

✓ **With a grown-up.** Hold hands near the street. A grown-up stays close.

MAKE IT YOURS

## Your own play

+

TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY

TALK TIP

Ages: 0–1 1–2 2–3 3–5



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS



## Play & Talk

Cards · Ages 0-5

PLAY BEFORE PIXELS

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

MAKE IT YOURS

**Your own play**



TITLE

YOU NEED

THE PLAY



TALK TIP

Ages: 0-1 1-2 2-3 3-5

# Our Play & Talk Year

One card a week is plenty. Check it off when you've played it, and color in the heart if your child asks for it again.

| ▲ 0–1 year                                                            | ■ 1–2 years                                                          | ★ 2–3 years                                                           | ● 3–5 years                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> 01 Peekaboo Cloth <input type="checkbox"/>   | <input type="checkbox"/> 14 Box Car <input type="checkbox"/>         | <input type="checkbox"/> 27 Blanket Fort <input type="checkbox"/>     | <input type="checkbox"/> 40 Story Box <input type="checkbox"/>       |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 02 Copy Cat Faces <input type="checkbox"/>   | <input type="checkbox"/> 15 Stir the Soup <input type="checkbox"/>   | <input type="checkbox"/> 28 Tea Party <input type="checkbox"/>        | <input type="checkbox"/> 41 Obstacle Course <input type="checkbox"/> |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 03 Kitchen Drum <input type="checkbox"/>     | <input type="checkbox"/> 16 Animal Voices <input type="checkbox"/>   | <input type="checkbox"/> 29 Color Sort <input type="checkbox"/>       | <input type="checkbox"/> 42 I Spy Colors <input type="checkbox"/>    |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 04 Where's Duck? <input type="checkbox"/>    | <input type="checkbox"/> 17 Pour and Splash <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> 30 Car Ramp <input type="checkbox"/>         | <input type="checkbox"/> 43 Restaurant <input type="checkbox"/>      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 05 Bubble Watch <input type="checkbox"/>     | <input type="checkbox"/> 18 Block Tower <input type="checkbox"/>     | <input type="checkbox"/> 31 Big Paper Art <input type="checkbox"/>    | <input type="checkbox"/> 44 Box Rocket <input type="checkbox"/>      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 06 Rock and Stop <input type="checkbox"/>    | <input type="checkbox"/> 19 Hat Parade <input type="checkbox"/>      | <input type="checkbox"/> 32 Freeze Dance <input type="checkbox"/>     | <input type="checkbox"/> 45 Kitchen List <input type="checkbox"/>    |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 07 Roll It Back <input type="checkbox"/>     | <input type="checkbox"/> 20 Pillow Mountain <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> 33 Sock Puppet Chat <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> 46 Do What I Do <input type="checkbox"/>    |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 08 First Book Chat <input type="checkbox"/>  | <input type="checkbox"/> 21 Sock Toss <input type="checkbox"/>       | <input type="checkbox"/> 34 Nature Basket <input type="checkbox"/>    | <input type="checkbox"/> 47 Shadow Animals <input type="checkbox"/>  |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 09 In and Out <input type="checkbox"/>       | <input type="checkbox"/> 22 Teddy's Bedtime <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> 35 Pretend Shop <input type="checkbox"/>     | <input type="checkbox"/> 48 Book Bridge <input type="checkbox"/>     |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 10 Leaf Hello <input type="checkbox"/>       | <input type="checkbox"/> 23 Chair Tunnel <input type="checkbox"/>    | <input type="checkbox"/> 36 Toy Bath <input type="checkbox"/>         | <input type="checkbox"/> 49 Sock Match <input type="checkbox"/>      |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 11 Tickle Countdown <input type="checkbox"/> | <input type="checkbox"/> 24 Clap and Stomp <input type="checkbox"/>  | <input type="checkbox"/> 37 Animal Moves <input type="checkbox"/>     | <input type="checkbox"/> 50 Water Painting <input type="checkbox"/>  |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 12 Stack and Crash <input type="checkbox"/>  | <input type="checkbox"/> 25 Pull-Out Box <input type="checkbox"/>    | <input type="checkbox"/> 38 Shape Hunt <input type="checkbox"/>       | <input type="checkbox"/> 51 Feelings Faces <input type="checkbox"/>  |
| <input type="checkbox"/> 13 Sock Off! <input type="checkbox"/>        | <input type="checkbox"/> 26 Kick and Chase <input type="checkbox"/>  | <input type="checkbox"/> 39 Little Helper <input type="checkbox"/>    | <input type="checkbox"/> 52 Sound Walk <input type="checkbox"/>      |

Our favorite play so far:

Our child's newest word or phrase:

# What's next



## Your free companion bonus

Scan the code or visit [playbeforepixels.com/bonus/play-talk-cards](https://playbeforepixels.com/bonus/play-talk-cards) for extra printable cards and a short, friendly idea by email each month.

We ask only for an email address and your child's birth month and year, never names. Unsubscribe any time.

## Next for your family



### Family Talk-Along Cards

Ages 5–12 · 52 questions for dinner, the car, bath time and bedtime



### "I'm Bored" Play Cards

Ages 1–12 · 150 age-banded screen-free plays, each with a talk prompt



### 100 Screen-Free Plays

Ages 0–5 · the activity book, sorted by age, with a talk line on every play

Find them all at [playbeforepixels.com](https://playbeforepixels.com). Bundles are offered at a fair discount.

## Which card did your family love?

A short, honest review on the shop where you bought this helps other families decide. Questions or ideas? Write to us through the contact form at [playbeforepixels.com/contact](https://playbeforepixels.com/contact).



52 Play & Talk Cards, Ages 0–5. Version 1.0 · September 2026. Printable PDF for personal and family use.

Parent education only. These cards are ideas for everyday play and conversation; they are not medical, developmental or professional advice and are not a substitute for care from a qualified professional. Always supervise children during play.

© 2026 AlphaPlay LLC. Play Before Pixels is a trade name of AlphaPlay LLC. All rights reserved. License: personal/family use only; full terms at [playbeforepixels.com/license](https://playbeforepixels.com/license).